



# Public Sector Certificate Program

## Expand your skills in public sector finance

The Public Sector Certificate provides the most comprehensive, practical and relevant public sector training for financial professionals in Canada. It is an ideal foundation for those seeking competitive senior positions in the public sector.



### Benefits you

- knowledgeable facilitators who offer extensive real-world experience in the public sector
- the most current Canadian curriculum to help you succeed in the marketplace
- professional development to complement your Canadian CPA designation



### Benefits your employer

- a positive impact at work as you progress through the program
- a unique format that accelerates your development in public sector finance
- quick, out-of-the-gate value in public sector accounting, financial reporting and financial management
- a strong return on their investment that fosters productivity and excellence



# Overview

## Program eligibility

This program is designed for those who do and do not have their Canadian CPA designation, recognizing the depth of experience within the public sector.

There are no prerequisites to register into the program, it is recommended that participants have a strong background in Finance or the equivalent of an accounting diploma.

## Integrated learning: with two levels

Immerse yourself in an exceptional educational environment that is flexible, interactive and complements other on-the-job training, using a unique two-level approach. Level I addresses public sector foundations, while Level II covers advanced topics in the public sector, concluding with a two-day capstone.

## A comprehensive curriculum

This certificate includes 40 hours of online modules in Level I and 30 hours of online modules in Level II, with real-life scenario application, case work and first-class facilitators.

Additionally, self-assessment checks along the way will help you evaluate your success at different stages of the program.

## Certification of Completion

When you successfully complete the Public Sector Certificate you will receive a CPA Canada Certificate of Completion, which is a nationally recognized symbol of excellence in continuing education.

# Program overview

## Level I

*(Available in English only)*

- 40 hours of interactive online learning
- assessment after each module and upon completion

## Level II

*(Available in English only)*

- 30 hours of interactive online learning and a 14-hour capstone
- curriculum focus on financial reporting and financial management

## Embedded principles

- ESG
- ethics
- accountability and transparency
- risk management
- communications

## Level II: Capstone

**Facilitated by experts in the public sector, the capstone session is a virtual two-day workshop**

In this capstone, you will collaborate with your peers on a variety of applied learning activities, including case studies about financial reporting, financial management and leadership in the public sector. It is the comprehensive final exercise required to complete the Public Sector Certificate.



# Level 1

| Module                                                                     | Learning objectives                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
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| <b>Governance and Decision-Making Processes</b>                            | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Identify the typical legislative authorities and provisions defining how governments receive, disburse and manage public funds.</li> <li>Introduce government stakeholders and their expectations of accountability, transparency, value for money and the sustainability of taxpayer-funded spending.</li> <li>Define the key ethical values for those employed in the public sector.</li> <li>Describe the elements of governance and decision-making in public sector environments, including how government staff work and communicate with elected officials and their staff at all levels of government.</li> </ul>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| <b>The Planning and Budgeting Process</b>                                  | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Introduce planning and budgeting processes within public sector organizations.</li> <li>Describe each government's budgeting process that culminates in its annual budget.</li> <li>Identify common concepts and phrases, and describe Expenditure Estimates and Supplementary Estimates.</li> <li>Explain the steps in the development of strategic and operational planning.</li> </ul>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| <b>Government Operating and Capital Budgets</b>                            | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Recognize the differences between operating and capital budgets, and funding for operations versus funding for capital.</li> <li>Explain how to prepare a budget component for a program, division or other small segment that will be rolled up into the overall budget.</li> <li>Describe how logic models translate strategic plan objectives and goals into the inputs and outputs of operational and capital plans.</li> <li>Summarize the capital asset management process.</li> </ul>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| <b>Decision Support</b>                                                    | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Explain the components within a Treasury Board submission, their importance and the way departments and agencies get new federal funding that the operational and capital Budgets reflect.</li> <li>Describe the use of project and program management within the public sector.</li> <li>Identify the way metrics and results-based performance help support decision-making.</li> </ul>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| <b>Assessing Accountability Through Performance Reporting and Auditing</b> | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Discuss the significance of performance reporting in the public sector, including approaches employed by municipal, provincial and federal governments to convey their results to the public.</li> <li>Define the concept of public sector auditing and its role in maintaining public accountability.</li> <li>Differentiate between private sector and public sector auditing, as well as between internal and external auditing within the public sector.</li> <li>Explain the auditing oversight mechanisms employed by federal, provincial and local governments to ensure public accountability and effective resource allocation.</li> <li>Identify the financial, control and related risks associated with government program delivery, including third-party organizations.</li> <li>Recognize process weaknesses and recommend appropriate financial and internal controls to address them.</li> <li>Describe the audit procedures employed to assess value-for-money and performance in government program delivery.</li> </ul> |



## Module

## Learning objectives

### **Environmental, Social and Governance Reporting within the Public Sector**

- Define the concept of sustainability by outlining its key components and principles in the context of organizational practices.
- Explain the distinctions and shared elements between sustainability and environmental, social, and governance (ESG) factors, providing a comprehensive understanding of their interrelation.
- Discuss the various factors that contribute to the growing demand for sustainability information, providing insights into the reasons behind the increased interest in this area.
- Identify the historical development of sustainability practices and reporting, tracing the evolution of methodologies and frameworks over time.
- Explain what ESG is and analyze its implications for public sector management program delivery.



# Level II

## Part 1: Financial reporting

| Module                                                                  | Learning objectives                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
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| <b>Introduction to Public Sector Financial Reporting and Accounting</b> | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>• Describe the role of PSAB in setting Canadian Public Sector Accounting Standards.</li><li>• Describe the process PSAB uses to set standards.</li><li>• Identify five other sources of GAAP and describe the conditions under which they may be considered in a public sector setting.</li><li>• Determine the appropriate basis of GAAP for a particular entity.</li><li>• Identify the objectives of public sector financial reporting and how it differs from the private sector.</li><li>• Describe the Conceptual Framework for Financial Reporting in the public sector.</li><li>• Identify the elements of public sector financial statements.</li></ul>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
| <b>Financial Statements</b>                                             | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>• Describe Section PS 1202, <i>Financial Statement Presentation</i>.</li><li>• Identify the differences between public sector financial statements and private sector financial statements.</li><li>• Explain the five mandatory financial statements in public sector under Section PS 1202.</li></ul>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| <b>Revenue</b>                                                          | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>• Define the term revenue.</li><li>• Identify typical sources of government revenue.</li><li>• Explain how standards apply to recognition, measurement, presentation and disclosure of revenue.</li><li>• Describe two alternatives for recognizing revenue in government not-for-profit organizations:<ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>— pure Public Sector Accounting Standards (also known as PSAS)</li><li>— PSAS adapted for Section PS 4200, <i>Financial Statement Presentation by Not-for-Profit Organizations</i> in the PSA Handbook</li></ul></li><li>• Explain how to account for three types of restricted assets and revenues as defined in Section PS 3100:<ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>— external restrictions</li><li>— internal restrictions</li><li>— designated assets</li></ul></li></ul>                                                                                                                                                   |
| <b>Tangible Capital Assets and Purchased Intangibles</b>                | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>• Explain the key definitions related to tangible capital assets as given in Section PS 3150.</li><li>• Evaluate how to account for tangible capital assets.</li><li>• Identify which items are not recorded as tangible capital assets.</li><li>• Explain the process for recording tangible capital assets.</li><li>• Describe the allocation of costs associated with tangible capital assets.</li><li>• Distinguish between repair and betterment costs.</li><li>• Determine an appropriate accounting policy for amortization of tangible capital assets.</li><li>• Recognize when write-downs should be recorded.</li><li>• Explain the presentation and disclosure requirements related to tangible capital assets.</li><li>• Identify when leases should be recorded as tangible capital assets.</li><li>• Define purchased intangibles and explain their characteristics.</li><li>• Determine an appropriate accounting treatment of purchased intangibles.</li></ul> |

| Module                      | Learning objectives                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
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| <b>Government Transfers</b> | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Explain the current standards for government transfers (Section PS 3410, <i>Government Transfers</i>, in the <i>CPA Canada Public Sector Accounting Handbook (PSA Handbook)</i>).</li> <li>• Explain the three types of government transfers.</li> <li>• Review the recognition criteria for government transfers from the perspectives of the transferor and the recipient.</li> <li>• Recall the practical issues in the application of Section PS 3410.</li> <li>• Identify the interaction between Section PS 3410, <i>Government Transfers</i> and Section PS 3050, <i>Loans Receivable</i>.</li> <li>• Determine the accounting treatment for forgivable loans and loans with significant concessionary terms.</li> </ul>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| <b>Liabilities</b>          | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Identify the key characteristics that define a liability.</li> <li>• Assess the completeness and appropriate measurement of liabilities.</li> <li>• Explain the requirements for liabilities for contaminated sites and for asset retirement obligations.</li> </ul>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| <b>Various Standards</b>    | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Public Private Partnerships Accounting Implications (Section PS 3160) <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>— Establish the purpose and scope of Section PS 3160.</li> <li>— Assess the criteria for recognition of infrastructure assets and liabilities.</li> <li>— Determine the initial and subsequent measurement for assets and liabilities of P3 arrangements under the financial liability and user-pay models.</li> <li>— Identify the presentation and disclosure requirements for P3s.</li> </ul> </li> <li>• Foreign Currency Translation Requirements (Section PS 2601) <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>— Define foreign currency transactions as per Section PS 2601.</li> <li>— Determine the appropriate recognition and measurement of foreign currency transactions under PS 2601.</li> <li>— Identify the presentation and disclosure implications of foreign currency translation on financial statements.</li> </ul> </li> <li>• Related party transactions (Section PS 2200 and Section PS 3420) <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>— Identify related parties including key management personnel and related party transactions.</li> <li>— Evaluate the accounting and reporting of related party transactions including measurement of inter-entity transactions.</li> <li>— Apply the disclosure requirements of related party transactions under PS 2200.</li> </ul> </li> <li>• Contingent assets (Section PS 3320) and Contractual rights (Section PS 3380) <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>— Define contingent assets and contractual rights.</li> <li>— Determine the accounting impacts of contingent assets and contractual rights in the financial statements.</li> </ul> </li> <li>• Restructuring transactions (Section PS 3430) <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>— Identify restructuring transactions.</li> <li>— Assess the accounting implications of restructuring transactions from the perspectives of transferor and transferee.</li> <li>— Apply the presentation and disclosure requirements of restructuring transactions under Section PS 3430.</li> </ul> </li> </ul> |



| Module                                 | Learning objectives                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
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| <b>Consolidation</b>                   | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Define the concept of the government reporting entity.</li> <li>• Assess whether control exists within various entities.</li> <li>• Identify indicators of control in government organizations.</li> <li>• Apply appropriate accounting methods for government organizations.</li> <li>• Determine the accounting treatments for different government units.</li> <li>• Recall the key principles of consolidation.</li> <li>• Explain how to account for investments.</li> </ul> |
| <b>Financial Instruments (PS 3450)</b> | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Recognize the key accounting principles under Section PS 3450.</li> <li>• Identify recognition criteria and measurement categories.</li> <li>• Explain the requirements for presentation and disclosure of financial instruments and risks.</li> </ul>                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| <b>Employee Future Benefits</b>        | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Explain various types of retirement benefit plans.</li> <li>• Determine accounting implications for defined benefit and defined contribution plans.</li> <li>• Describe the presentation and disclosure requirements for defined benefits and defined contribution plans.</li> <li>• Identify post-employment, compensated absences and termination benefits.</li> <li>• Recognize the differences between vested, accumulated and event-driven benefits.</li> </ul>              |



## Part 2: Module Breakdown

| Module                                        | Learning objectives                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
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| <b>The Public Sector Context</b>              | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>• Describe the characteristics that make government complex.</li><li>• Identify and define the core elements of public administration.</li><li>• Explain how government achieves its objectives.</li><li>• Describe public sector financial management and how it fits into the democratic process.</li><li>• Identify some competencies of financial management.</li></ul>                                               |
| <b>Risk Management</b>                        | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>• Describe the principles of risk management underlying the ISO standard and their application across different levels of government.</li><li>• Identify and describe various types of risk assessments and treatment methods.</li><li>• Explain the concept of risk financing and its role in managing organizational risks.</li></ul>                                                                                   |
| <b>Resource Management</b>                    | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>• Identify the nature and characteristics of effective resource management.</li><li>• Demonstrate how to use logic models.</li><li>• Explain stakeholders and external monitoring.</li><li>• Identify strategic reviews and reallocation.</li></ul>                                                                                                                                                                       |
| <b>Budgeting and Cost Estimation</b>          | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>• Explain the role of cost estimation in the budgeting process.</li><li>• Define cost estimation and identify the benefits, challenges, limitations, and qualities of robust and credible cost estimates.</li><li>• Identify types of cost estimates and cost estimating techniques and determine their appropriate applications.</li><li>• Describe various budgeting techniques and their suitable use cases.</li></ul> |
| <b>Performance Management and Measurement</b> | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>• Define performance management in the public sector.</li><li>• Describe performance measurement in the public sector.</li><li>• Identify performance improvement opportunities in the public sector.</li><li>• Explain the link between performance management and financial management (including the role of the public sector financial professional).</li></ul>                                                      |

## Level II Capstone

| Case Study                                 | Learning objectives                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
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| <b>Case Study 1:<br/>Municipal</b>         | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Knowing how to use the CPA Way to approach scenario analysis and communicate conclusions that support stakeholder decisions</li> <li>• Being able to assess a municipal case scenario that includes the following topics:               <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>– consolidation</li> <li>– revenue recognition</li> <li>– financial monitoring and management</li> <li>– resource management and efficiency</li> <li>– risk management and governance oversight</li> </ul> </li> </ul>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| <b>Case Study 2:<br/>Federal-Municipal</b> | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Being able to assess a federal-municipal transfer case scenario that includes the following topics:               <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>– government transfers</li> <li>– transfer of assets</li> <li>– post-employment benefits and compensated absences</li> <li>– change management</li> <li>– performance based budgeting</li> <li>– risk mitigation and sustainability assessment</li> </ul> </li> </ul>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| <b>Case Study 3:<br/>Provincial</b>        | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Being able to explain emerging issues in financial reporting, including examples in the following areas:               <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>– PS 1201: financial statement presentation</li> <li>– PS 3450: financial instruments</li> <li>– PS 3041: portfolio investments</li> <li>– PS 2601: foreign currency translation</li> </ul> </li> <li>• Being able to assess a provincial Ministry of Finance case scenario that includes the following areas:               <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>– financial management and control policies for new standards</li> <li>– training and coaching for successful process implementation</li> <li>– statement of remeasurement gains and losses</li> <li>– implementation of internal controls to address strategic outcomes</li> </ul> </li> </ul> |
| <b>Case Study 4:<br/>Provincial</b>        | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Being able to assess a provincial Ministry of Energy case scenario that includes the following topics:               <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>– financial reporting for a government business enterprise</li> <li>– contaminated sites liability</li> <li>– performance management and measurement</li> <li>– communication strategies</li> </ul> </li> </ul>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |



**For more information**

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